

But more than that, his theory about the preservation of the New Testament by means of the group of manuscripts that he identifies as Family 35 is endowed with an epistemological solidity, with a methodological rigor and with an apologetic value that are equally impressive.

From an epistemological and apologetic point of view, his work starts with the presuppositional premise that God delivered a written revelation to the human race, and that would not make sense if His divine providence were not going to preserve that written revelation. As with every epistemological first principle, this point needs to be presupposed, and Dr. Pickering has always insisted upon making his presuppositions very clear, thereby demonstrating intellectual honesty.

But it is in the analysis of the empirical evidence that the impressive methodological rigor of Dr. Pickering's theory resides.

Although I insist upon emphasizing that his theory has a presuppositional epistemological base, I will nevertheless introduce a consideration of the empirical evidences using a completely different axis. As a consequence of the recent impact that scholars like Alvin Plantinga and William Lane Craig have contributed to my studies, I will now use modal logic to work on the base of an evidential apologetic.

Therefore, after making clear that the lines that follow refer exclusively to a work of persuasive argumentation, using modal logic, that I am here elaborating (and not to the way in which Dr. Pickering constructs his arguments), I can enunciate the following premises as a basis for reasoning about the preservation of the New Testament Text exemplified by Family 35.

1. It is possible that God delivered a written revelation to the human race.
2. If God delivered such a revelation to us, it is reasonable that it would be preserved.
3. The existence of a preserved text confirms 1) and 2).
4. The only type of text that objectively exemplifies 3) is that of Family 35.

To believe that God exists is a decision of faith. But it is not an irrational faith, since the Christian faith constitutes, as Alvin